2026 IFI Fatherhood Essay Contest

Deadline: March 19

Student's Name / Nombre del Estudiante Ethan Garcia

Grade / Grado 8

Father/Father-Figure Name / Nombre del Padre/Figura Paterna Azucena Boyas

School / Escuela Rachel Carson Elementary

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Writing About / Escribiendo Sobre:

- ○ Father / Padre
- ○ Grandfather / Abuelo
- ○ Stepdad / Padrasto
- ◉ Father-Figure / Figura Paterna

"What my father or an important father-figure* means to me"

"Lo que mi padre o una figura paterna importante* significa para mí"

Fatherhood Essay

My Aunt's name is Ascucena Boyas, she was born on September 8, 1993 in Chicago, Illinois. She is Funny, Hardworking and Helpful. The best memory I have with my aunt is when we both had a day off and it was just us in her apartment. We were waiting for someone to come and check on the outlets in the apartment. First we had to jump her car because her car didn't start the day before. It was scary but thankfully I watched videos on how to do it the day before. The car started so she took it to the mechanic to figure out what was wrong with it. When she came back we decided to watch the original IT while we decided on what to eat. We decided to order Mexican food and we ate together while talking. That day felt amazing and I love when we can be alone together and have conversations that just flow together.

My Aunt is the heart of my family because she's hardworking. I know she is a hardworking person because she does a lot for everyone in my family and still manages to hold herself together. She also works a lot just so my cousins and I can have food on the table. She's able to help out my mom, grandpa, cousins and still find time for herself. My Aunt does a lot for us and she isn't verbally thanked for it, but she still does it for us anyway. My Aunt is a very important part of my family.

Another way my aunt is the heart of my family is that she's helpful . She's helpful because she helps me get through tough times. Like when the fire happened and me and my mom didn't have anywhere to go she helped us pick a place to stay. So we ended up at the hotel and during this spring break, we are going to move into a temporary home. She also helps my grandpa by making his dinners and lunches during the weekend. She also helps my mom by getting us groceries and dinner. As you can see she is very helpful to my family.

The final way my aunt is the heart of my family is that she is very responsible. She is responsible because she is very good at managing things. She is also the best with money. Also she can take care of my cousins, Me and my grandpa really well. Finally she is really good at managing bad situations . Like when the fire on my house happened she managed to comfort me and everyone while she was still processing it. Or when my other aunt wouldn't move out of my grandpa's house she handled it calmly while she still had other feelings for it she did it the most responsible way. I know she wanted to do other things but she kept calm and she doesn't get thanked for this

3000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

Father/Grandfather/Step-Dad/Father-Figure reaction to this essay:

Reacción de padre/abuelo/padrastro/figura paterna a este ensayo:

2000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

** Father-Figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.*

**Una figura paterna puede ser un padrastro, un abuelo, un tío, un pastor/rabino/chamán, Dios, o un visión ideal de un padre.*

CONTEST DETAILS

Each student is asked to write a 3000 character (or less) essay on the theme “What My Father or an Important Father-Figure Means to Me,” describing their relationship with their father or father-figure. Students should share their true feelings. Provide examples of joys, frustrations or special memories they have as well as commenting about what they would most like to see in their relationship. A father-figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, coach, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.

CRITERIA FOR ESSAY JUDGING

Submissions will be evaluated according to grade level. Judging criteria will consist of:

1. How the essay describes the relationship.
2. Detail and stories that demonstrate the character of the father/father-figure.
3. Honesty, clarity, simplicity of writing.
4. Overall grade level appropriate writing skill.

JUDGING PROCESS

1. Essays will be divided into the 13 grade levels (K-12).
2. Volunteers will use the above judging criteria, reading every essay. Top essays from the first round will be sent to a final essay reading session.
3. At the final essay reading, volunteers will then select 10 essays per grade. Up to 130 essay semi-finalists will receive special recognition.
4. The top 13 essay writers will be invited to the IFI Fatherhood Dinner Celebration.
5. All entrants will receive a Certificate of Participation.

RULES

1. One entry per person.
2. All essays must be original, unaided by AI and created by the student.
3. All entries become the property of Illinois Fatherhood Initiative (IFI). IFI will not be able to return them.
4. Entry into the contest transfers copyright of the essay to IFI and grants IFI permission to reproduce without compensation all or any portion of the essay and response on an unlimited, world-wide basis in its publications and media channels.
5. When appropriate and with parent/guardian permission, IFI will cite the name of the author(s) if significant portions of a positive essay/response are used. IFI will also change or conceal names to maintain confidentiality if requested.
6. Contest is open to Illinois students (K-12).
7. Deadline for upload or postmark is March 19th.
8. Completed forms can be uploaded on 4dads.org or mailed to:

    1515 S. Grove Avenue, #3667, Barrington, IL 60011.